Jew to Israel, he would still fall 1 million people short, and would need all of Los Angeles and Miami to hit his quota.) “I know this might sound unrealistic to some, and others will say that it is merely a slogan,” he said. Then he echoed Theodor Herzl’s quote about the founding of a Jewish state. “However, I say, ‘If you will it, it is no dream.’”

For a couple of years, Israeli officials anticipated a major influx of French immigrants. Their numbers had long hovered around 2,000, many of them older people who wanted to retire in Israel. But the tally surged in 2014, and peaked at around 7,900 in 2015, making France the largest source of new arrivals. The demographics shifted as well, with young people and families joining the retirees. Many of them settled in Ra’anana, a suburb north of Tel Aviv that has long been a magnet for new immigrants, first from English-speaking countries, then Latin America. In recent years, it has acquired a slightly Parisian feel. Many shops advertise their wares in French alongside Hebrew and English, and the language can often be heard in cafés and parks. Imported products like wine and cheese are readily available. Schoolchildren stop at bakeries for croissants on their way home instead of falafel.

But many of them found living in Israel a struggle: the new language, the high cost of living, the scarcity of good French cheeses (a complaint I heard several times). One of the most common gripes was the difficulty in transferring their qualifications—in getting a French doctor licensed to practice medicine in Israel, for example. “You work longer hours for less money here,” said Rachel Kakon, a hairdresser, over coffee and chouquettes at a patisserie on Ben Gurion Street. “It’s an easier life in France, the schools, child care, everything is easier.” Many left to escape a stagnant economy, where the jobless rate stands at 10 per cent, and nearly 25 per cent for the young, but Israel offered its own set of economic problems. “It’s a very complicated scenario. You have to remember, the Jews aren’t the only ones leaving France. There’s a general pattern of emigration,” said Yigal Palmor, a spokesman for the Jewish Agency. “And the Jews who leave, not all of them are going to Israel. It’s not their only option.”

The pudding crisis

Israelis traveling abroad occasionally post photos of Tnuva cheeses or Golan wines in Western grocery stores. They are, inevitably and